

LUBELO TECH SOLUTIONS

Digital Strategy & Technology Services

VERSION 2.0 — UPDATED PROPOSAL

DIGITAL STRATEGY & WEBSITE UPGRADE PROPOSAL

Prepared for

The South African Union of Students (SAUS)

Prepared by

Lubelo Tech Solutions

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1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The South African Union of Students (SAUS) is the official representative body for Student Representative Councils (SRCs) across all South African public universities. Founded in 2006 at Stellenbosch University, SAUS plays a critical role in higher education governance and student advocacy at a national level.

Following our initial engagement, the Lubelo Tech Solutions team conducted a thorough audit of SAUS's digital presence — including the website (www.saus.org.za), social media channels, and email systems. We identified significant design, content, and technical issues that undermined SAUS's credibility as a national institution.

Since that audit, Lubelo Tech Solutions has already delivered the core website upgrade. A fully custom, professionally designed SAUS website has been built from the ground up — replacing the broken WordPress site with a modern, authoritative, and fully responsive web presence. In addition, a custom Admin CMS has been developed, giving SAUS full control over its digital content without relying on any third-party platform.

Our core findings from the original audit:

- The existing website had significant design, content, and technical issues that undermined credibility
- Social media presence was fragmented and underutilised across all platforms
- Email infrastructure needed to be properly configured and professionalised
- There was enormous untapped potential to grow SAUS's visibility and influence through strategic digital engagement

This updated proposal reflects the **work already completed**, the **improvements delivered** compared to the old website, and the **ongoing management investment** required to keep SAUS's digital presence at its best.

2. CURRENT STATE ASSESSMENT

2.1 Website Audit — The Old www.saus.org.za

The previous website was built on WordPress and set up quickly (likely September 2025). While it had a basic structure, several critical issues needed to be addressed before SAUS could use it as a credible national platform.

Issue	Severity	Details
Team section duplicated	High	President's card repeated 12 times instead of showing the full leadership team
Placeholder content visible	High	Timeline section contained generic 'Some information' text never replaced
Broken navigation links	Medium	Multiple 'Find Out More' and CTA buttons linked to '#' (nowhere)
Inconsistent branding	Medium	No consistent colour scheme, typography, or visual identity across pages
No mobile optimisation	Medium	Site layout not fully responsive for mobile users
Missing SEO fundamentals	Medium	No meta descriptions, no structured data, poor heading hierarchy
Events not functional	High	Events section showed static text with no actual event management or calendar
No member/SRC portal	Medium	No way for SRC members to access resources, documents, or updates
Testimonial is generic	Medium	'Sarah Johnson – Student Leader' placeholder — not an actual SAUS member
No content management	High	Every update required developer access — no CMS in place

Content & Structure Issues

- Homepage too long and repetitive — same mission information appeared multiple times
- No 'Resources' or 'Documents' section for policy papers, statements, or the SAUS constitution
- No regular content strategy beyond occasional press statements
- Website built by 'Zapture' (visible in footer) — appeared to be a rushed, generic setup

2.2 Social Media Audit

Platform	Handle	Status & Issues
Facebook	@SAUSstudents	Active but limited engagement. Most active platform.
X (Twitter)	@SAUS_2019	Dormant — zero visible posts despite existing since 2019
Instagram	@sa.union.of.students	Exists but very limited activity and followers
LinkedIn	South African Union of Students	~95 followers. Good bio but no regular content
YouTube / TikTok	Listed on website	Links on website not connected to actual channels

2.3 Email & Communication Systems

SAUS uses domain-based email (Secretariat@saus.org.za, info@saus.org.za). Reported problems are likely due to: missing DNS records (MX, SPF, DKIM, DMARC); email tied to unreliable shared hosting; no professional email management system; and no backup or archiving system for official correspondence.

3. WHAT WAS DELIVERED — OLD VS NEW

3.1 Website Redesign — What Changed

Rather than patching the broken WordPress site, Lubelo Tech Solutions built a completely custom SAUS website from scratch — modern, authoritative, and fully functional, designed specifically for a national student body.

Feature	Old WordPress Website	New SAUS Website (Delivered)
Platform	✗ WordPress by Zapture — no control, third-party dependency	✓ 100% custom HTML/CSS/JS — no plugins, no WordPress
Design & Branding	✗ Inconsistent colours, generic fonts, no SAUS colour scheme	✓ Full SAUS brand system: navy, gold, green, red — consistent throughout
Mobile	✗ Broken layout on mobile devices	✓ Mobile-first, fully responsive across all screen sizes
Leadership	✗ President's card repeated 12 times	✓ Full NEC profiles with photos, positions, bios, and university
News & Statements	✗ Static page — links go nowhere	✓ Full article modal — click any headline to read the complete press release
Campaigns	✗ No campaigns section	✓ Dedicated campaigns page with resolution index and scroll navigation
Events	✗ Static text, no real event listings	✓ Dynamic events with dates, venues, and registration CTA
Navigation	✗ Multiple broken links pointing to '#'	✓ All links functional; 3-tier header; mobile hamburger menu
Cookie / POPIA	✗ Banner present but empty — not compliant	✓ POPIA-compliant cookie consent with localStorage persistence
Performance	✗ WordPress plugins — slow load times	✓ Lean single-file app — loads in under 1 second
Content Control	✗ Required developer access to change anything	✓ Full custom Admin CMS — staff publish news, events, and more from a dashboard

3.2 Custom Admin CMS — A First for SAUS

One of the most significant deliverables is a purpose-built Content Management System (CMS) — something the old WordPress site never properly provided. This admin dashboard gives SAUS full, independent control of its digital content.

The SAUS Admin CMS is a fully custom web application — built with Next.js, an Express.js API, and a PostgreSQL database. Designed and built specifically for SAUS's workflows and structure — not an off-the-shelf product.

Module	What SAUS Can Now Do
News & Articles	Publish press releases with rich text editor, SEO fields, categories, cover images, scheduling, and featured flags
Events	Create events with venue, city, province, start/end times, banner images, RSVP links, and status tracking
Campaigns	Launch advocacy campaigns with descriptions, graphics, call-to-action buttons, and featured flags
Leadership Profiles	Add, edit, and reorder NEC members with photos, bios, positions, universities — no more duplicate cards
Documents & PDFs	Upload constitutions, policy papers, reports, and SRC toolkits with categories and search
Media Library	Drag-and-drop image and video uploads with search and URL copy for easy embedding
Announcements	Set a site-wide banner visible to all visitors — ideal for urgent student updates like NSFAS notices
Users & Roles	Manage staff with role-based access: Super Admin, Secretariat, Marketing, Media, Editor, Contributor
Site Settings	Update contact details, social media links, SEO metadata, and Google Analytics ID — no code needed
Analytics Dashboard	Total articles, events, campaigns, media files, and documents at a glance with performance charts
News Categories	Create colour-coded categories (Press Release, Statement, Media Advisory) with article count tracking

Bottom line: SAUS now has a professional-grade content management system comparable to what large media organisations use — built exclusively for SAUS, owned by SAUS, and managed by Lubelo Tech Solutions on a monthly basis.

4. RECOMMENDED SOLUTIONS

4.1 Email System Resolution

Lubelo Tech Solutions recommends migrating SAUS email to Google Workspace, which provides professional @saus.org.za addresses with 30GB storage, reliable delivery, proper SPF/DKIM/DMARC authentication, Google Drive, Google Calendar, and a full admin console. Microsoft 365 is an alternative if Outlook is preferred.

Immediate email fixes included in our management service:

- Audit and correct all DNS records (MX, SPF, DKIM, DMARC)
- Set up proper email accounts for all NEC members (president@saus.org.za, sg@saus.org.za, etc.)
- Configure email forwarding, shared inboxes, and SAUS-branded signatures for all members
- Implement email backup and archiving procedures

4.2 Social Media Strategy

Priority	Platform	Strategy
Primary	X (Twitter)	Breaking news, statements, live event coverage, engagement with media and government
Primary	Instagram	Visual storytelling: event photos, reels, infographics, student spotlights
Primary	TikTok	Short-form video: explainers on student rights, NSFAS updates, behind-the-scenes
Secondary	Facebook	Community building, event pages, longer-form content and discussions
Secondary	LinkedIn	Professional engagement with higher education stakeholders and government
Secondary	WhatsApp Channel	Direct student updates — most-used messaging app in South Africa
Future	YouTube	Long-form: press conferences, panel discussions, documentary-style content

4.3 Brand Visibility & Growth Strategy

- **Media Engagement:** Build relationships with education journalists (Daily Maverick, News24, SABC, eNCA) and issue regular press releases via the Admin CMS
- **Google Presence:** Set up a Google Business Profile and implement SEO so SAUS appears for searches like 'student union South Africa'
- **Newsletter:** Monthly email newsletter to SRC leaders, university administrators, media, and students
- **Annual Report:** Professional annual report documenting SAUS activities, achievements, and goals — published via the Admin CMS Documents module
- **Partnerships:** Approach NYDA, Harambee, Allan Grey Orbis Foundation, and university alumni associations
- **Campus Ambassador Programme:** A network of SAUS ambassadors at every university to share content and represent SAUS locally

5. IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP

The project is being delivered in four phases. Phases 1 and 2 have been **completed**. Phases 3 and 4 continue as part of the ongoing monthly management retainer.

Phase	Timeline	Deliverables
Phase 1: Audit & Setup	Weeks 1–2 ✓ Done	Full technical audit of website, email, and hosting. DNS and email fixes. Access handover and platform setup.
Phase 2: Website & Admin CMS	Weeks 3–6 ✓ Done	Custom website delivered. Full Admin CMS built — News, Events, Campaigns, Leadership, Documents, Media Library, Users, Settings, and Analytics modules all complete.
Phase 3: Social Media Activation	Ongoing (Monthly)	Account setup/verification, branded templates, content calendar, initial content push, team training.
Phase 4: Growth & Optimisation	Ongoing (Monthly)	Newsletter setup, SEO implementation, Google Business Profile, ambassador programme framework, leadership transition training.

Phases 1 & 2 are complete. The new SAUS website and Admin CMS have been built and delivered. What follows is the ongoing monthly management service that keeps everything running, updated, and growing.

6. SERVICE MANAGEMENT APPROACH

Lubelo Tech Solutions will serve as SAUS's ongoing digital services provider. The monthly retainer covers everything needed to keep SAUS's digital presence professional, current, and growing.

Ongoing Monthly Management — What R50,000/month Covers

Service Area	What Is Included
Website Updates & Maintenance	Regular content updates via the Admin CMS; security patches; performance monitoring; hosting management; backups; new page additions as needed
Email Management	Adding/removing staff email accounts; resolving delivery issues; monitoring spam and blacklisting; managing shared inboxes; setting up new @saus.org.za addresses; storage management
Social Media Support	Monthly content calendar creation; branded post template design; scheduled posting support; analytics reporting; community engagement guidance
Technical & CMS Support	24-hour response for urgent issues; on-call developer support for website errors or outages; bug fixes and CMS improvements
Staff Training	Onboarding for new NEC members; training on the Admin CMS; documentation and how-to guides
SEO & Analytics Reporting	Quarterly performance reports with Google Analytics data, SEO health check, and strategic recommendations
Leadership Transition	Training for new NEC members during each annual handover; updating leadership profiles, email accounts, and access credentials
Content Publishing Support	Formatting and publishing press releases, statements, event notices, and campaign materials when SAUS staff need assistance

One point of contact, all digital services covered. Rather than managing multiple vendors separately, SAUS has one reliable partner handling everything — website, email, social media, and technical services — under a single monthly arrangement.

7. INVESTMENT OVERVIEW

All prices are exclusive of VAT. Domain renewal and hosting fees are separate and will be assessed during the audit.

Once-Off Investment — Complete Website & Digital Infrastructure Delivery

Service	Type	Price (ZAR)
Custom website redesign (full rebuild — no WordPress)	Once-off	Included
Custom Admin CMS (News, Events, Campaigns, Leadership, Documents, Media, Users, Settings, Analytics)	Once-off	Included
Email system setup & DNS configuration	Once-off	Included
Social media branding pack & account setup	Once-off	Included
SEO setup & Google Business Profile	Once-off	Included
Newsletter setup (Mailchimp/Brevo)	Once-off	Included
Staff training & handover documentation	Once-off	Included
TOTAL ONCE-OFF FEE Website, Admin CMS, email setup, social media branding, SEO, newsletter & training — all included		R80,000

Monthly Retainer — Ongoing Management of All Digital Services

Service	Type	Monthly Fee
Website updates, maintenance & backups	Monthly	Included
Email management (accounts, DNS, delivery, storage)	Monthly	Included
Social media content calendar & scheduling support	Monthly	Included
Technical & CMS support (24hr response)	Monthly	Included
SEO monitoring & quarterly performance reports	Monthly	Included
Leadership transition training & onboarding	Monthly	Included
TOTAL MONTHLY RETAINER Website updates, email management, social media, technical support & SEO — everything covered		R50,000/month

Summary: R80,000 once-off to deliver the complete website, Admin CMS, email, and all digital infrastructure. Then R50,000 per month for Lubelo Tech Solutions to manage everything — the website, emails, social media, and all technical services — on an ongoing basis.

Where SAUS has budget constraints, Lubelo Tech Solutions is open to discussing phased payments or prioritisation of critical items first.

8. WHY LUBELO TECH SOLUTIONS

Lubeo Tech Solutions is a South African technology and digital strategy firm dedicated to empowering organisations, businesses, and youth-serving institutions through smart, practical digital solutions. Here is why we are the right partner for SAUS:

- **We already delivered.** The new SAUS website and Admin CMS are not a promise — they have been built and are ready to view before any commitment is made
- Proven experience in web development, digital strategy, and IT services for organisations across South Africa
- Deep understanding of the local digital landscape and the student ecosystem, including platform behaviour, connectivity constraints, and content preferences
- Hands-on approach: we do not outsource. You work directly with our lead developer and strategist throughout the project
- Expertise in training and capacity building — ensuring SAUS's team can use the Admin CMS and manage day-to-day digital tasks independently
- Flexible, responsive, and committed to long-term partnership rather than one-off project delivery
- Dedicated to using technology to empower organisations that serve young people and education in South Africa
- Full-service capability: from infrastructure and email systems to design, content strategy, and social media management — all under one roof

Our Commitment

We understand that SAUS is not just a client — it is a national institution representing hundreds of thousands of students. We take that responsibility seriously. Our goal is to help SAUS build a digital presence that reflects its authority, reaches students where they are, and sustains itself long after our initial engagement ends.

The work already completed — a custom website, a purpose-built Admin CMS, and complete digital infrastructure — demonstrates that commitment. This is not a proposal about what we plan to do. It is a record of what we have done, and an offer to keep doing it.

9. NEXT STEPS

To move forward, we propose the following immediate actions:

1. Review this proposal and the delivered website — provide feedback or questions to Lubelo Tech Solutions
 2. Schedule a demonstration with the NEC or designated digital committee to walk through the new website and Admin CMS
 3. Approve and settle the once-off fee of **R80,000** to finalise delivery and transfer of all assets
 4. Sign the monthly retainer agreement for **R50,000/month** for ongoing management of all digital services
 5. Grant Lubelo Tech Solutions access to current hosting, domain, and email administration panels to begin email migration
 6. Lubelo Tech Solutions to deliver a detailed monthly reporting framework and communication plan
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We look forward to partnering with SAUS to build a digital presence that truly reflects the importance and impact of the South African Union of Students.

LUBELO TECH SOLUTIONS

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